



Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospitals Group

OFFICIAL

Policy

Exemption from Patient Prescription Co-payment for Mental Health Patients

Reference #: FSFHG-MENH-POL-0008

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
Fremantle Hospital (FH)	Mental Health	Medical and Pharmacy

1. Introduction

Patients of Mental Health Services are expected to pay for prescription medication.

Where a patient is under a Community Treatment Order (CTO) or on weekly clozapine prescriptions due to blood test requirements the patient is exempt from a co-payment for these medications. Additionally patients who qualify for Closing the Gap (CTG) program are also exempt from payment as per the WA Health patient fees and charges manual. In circumstances where payment is demonstrated to lead to an inability to access prescribed treatment, the patient may be granted exemption from payment on the approval of the SMHS Mental Health (MH) Service Director. This document outlines the requirements for granting these exemptions.

2. Terminology

Co-payment	A set contribution charge for each prescription
PPCEA	Pharmacy Patient Co-payment Exemption Application form.
Best Practice	Medication Management and Support Program

3. Policy

3.1. Community Treatment Order

- Where the patient is being treated under a CTO, the prescriber will complete the PPCEA form, available on the FH Pharmacy Sharepoint page, indicating exemption from payment of co-payment for all medication prescribed at the Mental Health Service.
 - The PPCEA does not require approval from the Service Director.
 - The exemption form is not required if the patient is only receiving a depot.
 - After completion the form can be sent via email directly to Pharmacy for filing and the payment exemption spreadsheet will be updated by the FH Team Lead Pharmacist.

3.2. Weekly Clozapine Prescribing

- Patients are not required to pay a co-payment for clozapine prescriptions (this does not include other medication the patients may receive from the community mental health clinic) under the following circumstances:
 - Where a patient is prescribed a maximum of one weeks supply of clozapine for the first 18 weeks of therapy
 - Where the patient is prescribed a maximum of one weeks supply for a re-titration caused by an interruption of therapy
 - Where the patient requires more frequent laboratory monitoring and consequently receives a smaller supply of clozapine
- During the weekly or twice weekly prescribing period, the prescriber may chose to complete a PPCEA form indicating exemption from co-payment for clozapine prescriptions
- The completed form can be sent straight to pharmacy for filing; Service Director approval is not required.

3.3. Closing the Gap (CTG) Patients

- As per the WA Health patient fees and charges manual any medication supplies to patients eligible for the Closing the Gap program are non chargeable.
- A PPCEA form is to be completed by the prescriber and forwarded to pharmacy. Prior approval from the Service Director is not required.

3.4. Financial Hardship

- Where the prescriber believes that the patient is experiencing (severe or particular) financial hardship such that their inability to pay is likely to lead

to their inability to access prescribed treatment, the prescriber will apply to the SMHS MH Service Director for approval to grant exemption, using the PPCEA.

- The prescriber must provide evidence to satisfy the criteria on the application form. Patient must meet one or more of the following exemption criteria:
 - raising a patient charge will put the patient at risk
 - there is evidence of non-compliance related to payment issues
 - there is financial hardships such as homelessness
- Any written evidence such as social work reports should also be attached to the email.
- The exemption form will be forwarded to the SMHS MH Service Director for final approval.
- If approval is granted, the prescriber may then provide exemption for a maximum of 3 months. Exemption will not be provided without prior approval.
- If the exemption is denied by the Service Director, the form will still be sent to pharmacy for recording purposes.

3.5. Review

- Applications due to financial hardship will be sent to the SMHS MH Service Director for final approval before being filed with pharmacy.
- Applications that are rejected will be returned to the prescriber and pharmacy with the reason for rejection recorded on the document.
- Exemption from payment must be reviewed every 3 months. It is the prescriber's responsibility to ensure that approval is sought in a timely manner. Exemption will not be provided without prior approval.
- Prescriptions for the patient must not exceed the time frame of the exemption.

3.6. Maintaining List of Current Exemptions

- The FH MH Team Lead Pharmacist will maintain a database of all current exemptions
- Upon receiving an exemption approval, a reminder will be set up in the relevant patient's Best Practice profile stating when the exemption will expire.
- This list will be accessible to Fremantle Hospital Pharmacy Department and the Community Liaison Pharmacist (CLP) in North Metropolitan Health

Service – Mental Health (NMHS-MH), and the list is sent monthly to the Adult Community Program Manager for further distribution

- NMHS-MH CLP will screen voucher claims against exemptions list and provide FH Pharmacy a monthly report of breaches. FH MH Team Lead Pharmacist to review and forward confirmed breaches to relevant doctors for immediate action. The SMHS MH Service Director and FH Mental Health Head of Service are included in this email for notification.
- This will enable:
 - Easy exemption checks
 - Easy access to exemption information for patients moving between teams
 - Reminders will be displayed in Best Practice software for the individual patient
 - Policy document compliance to be audited

4.Compliance/Performance Monitoring

- Compliance with this policy is conducted monthly as part of the Community Liaison Pharmacist (CLP) in North Metropolitan Health Service – Mental Health (NMHS-MH) program
- The total number of exempt patients for all categories will be monitored from vouchers that are claimed by community pharmacies. These figures will be reported by NMHS MH CLP each month when the MH voucher statistics are provided to the FH MH Team Lead Pharmacist. These figures will be reported to the SMHS MH Service Director, Adult Community Program Manager and FH Mental Health Head of Department on a monthly basis.

5.Related Policy Documents

- FSFHG
 - Medication Charging and Supply Policy
- WA Health
 - Patient fees and charges manual

6. Related Standards

- NSQHS
 - Medication safety
- NSMHS Standard
 - Delivery of care

7. Authorisation

EXECUTIVE SPONSOR: Medical Director Service 2					
Version	Date Issued	Compiled/Revised By	Committee/Consumer Group Consulted	Endorsed By	Revision due
1	01/2019	Taryn Fyfe, A/Chief Pharmacist, Fremantle Hospital	DTC Committee	Policy or Executive Committee	02/2022
2	06/2022	Chief Pharmacist, Fremantle Hospital	S5 SQR, DTC Committee	DTC Committee	06/2025
3	10/2025	Chief Pharmacist, Fremantle Hospital	DTC Committee	Service 5 SQR Committee	10/2028

8. Appendices

8.1. Appendix 1: Application for Exemption Flow Chart

